injuries, he was now back on active duty. When he came to know that I was in Trincomalee, he called me over to his HQ, where he gave me some life-saving tips on how to operate on the island. 'Whatever you do,' he said, 'don't ever walk on a jungle trail, because that's where the mines are.' Better to bash through the jungle, even if it meant taking a longer route or more time. The easy route was the route to death. For his action in that operation, Nandu was awarded the Sena Medal (Gallantry). He still has pieces of shrapnel in his body, which make the metal detectors at the airport go 'beep-beep-beep' every time he passes through, a constant reminder of when he hung between life and death.

About a year after the Bn's arrival, the situation in Trincomalee stabilized. Given the improved situation within the town, it was felt that a Company could be redeployed to the outskirts, dominating the jungles leading to Trincomalee. This was barely two months after my reporting to the unit. Accordingly, Bravo Company was moved to the 4th Mile Junction, with the Company HQ and one Platoon at the 4th Mile Post itself, and two Platoons about 5 km further eastwards along the Batticaloa (Batti) road, near a village called Villamkulam. There used to be a causeway across the harbour, connecting Trincomalee in the North via Mutur to Batticaloa to the South, which had been destroyed in the fighting between the SLA and the LTTE. As a result, all convoys now had to take the Batti Road and go all the way around. This road had the reputation for being extremely prone to IED attacks and needed to be sanitized by road opening parties (ROP) before any movement was allowed. The road was equally important for the SLA, which had posts strung out at regular intervals, with their Bn HQ at the Monkey Bridge Camp, then occupied by the 4th Battalion Sri Lanka Light Infantry. This 'Light

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